



The earliest European illustration of a cannon, from a book by Walter de Milemete, presented to the future Edward III of England in 1326.

GUNPOWDER WAS SLOWLY BUT STEADILY CHANGING THE FACE OF WARFARE.

Arabs and Moors had probably gained knowledge of gunpowder from the **Chinese**, using cannons in Spain as early as 1284. The **Mamluks** are believed to have used **handguns** at Ain Jalut, while the Mongols acquired the technology on conquering China. Europeans probably picked it up from **Spain** and contact with the **Mongols**. The first record of cannons forged from iron comes from Metz in 1324; later that year an English fortress in Gascony was bombarded for a month.

The **Mali Empire** of West Africa reached its height under **Mansa Musa** (r. 1312–37), extending from the Atlantic to Nigeria, and from the Sahara to the rain forest. His great wealth was based on **Mali's gold**, and when he traveled on pilgrimage to Mecca in 1324–25, he dispensed so much gold on his

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THE PERCENTAGE OF TIMBUKTU'S POPULATION AT SANKORE UNIVERSITY

passage through **Cairo** that he destabilized the economy. On his return, he employed an Andalusian architect to build a new palace at **Timbuktu**, which became a center for **Islamic scholarship**. Mali was later visited by the Moroccan scholar **Ibn Battuta** (c. 1304–69), who first set out on his travels in 1325.



The travels of Ibn Battuta

Ibn Battuta's first journey was the **Hajj** (pilgrimage) to Mecca. He made seven further journeys, visiting almost every corner of the Muslim world.



The gilded bronze doors on the Baptistry in Florence, sculpted and cast by Andrea Pisano, took six years to make after he won the commission in 1329.

FLORENCE IN THE 1320s AND 1330s WAS HOME TO ARTISTS

including **Giotto di Bondone** (c. 1267–1337) and **Andrea Pisano** (c. 1290–1349)—both seen as forerunners of the Italian Renaissance (see pp.208–09). Giotto painted naturalistic frescoes on the walls of the **Basilica of Santa Croce** in around 1325, and in 1334 was put in charge of the construction of the **Duomo** (cathedral). Greatly influenced by Giotto, Pisano won a commission to craft a set of **bronze doors for the Baptistry of Florence**, finishing them in 1336.

The **Tughluk dynasty** of the Delhi sultanate had expanded the reach of the **Muslim** state, reducing neighboring **Hindu kingdoms** to vassal status, and repelling a series of **Mongol incursions**. In 1325, **Muhammad Tughluk** (c. 1300–51) murdered his father and took the throne, and established a reputation for cruelty. In 1327, he transferred the capital from Delhi to **Daulatabad** for defensive reasons, forcing the population to relocate. In 1336, **Harihara I** and his brother **Bukka** of the **Sangama dynasty** in the

south, led a revolt that resulted in the establishment of the last great Hindu empire in India, centered on the city of **Vijayanagar**.

Edward II of England invested power in favorites, especially **Piers Gaveston** (murdered by resentful barons in 1312) and the **Despensers** family. He also alienated his wife, **Isabella of France**, who was sent to France in 1325 to arrange the marriage of their son. While there, she became the lover of **Roger Mortimer**, and when they returned, in 1326, they led a **revolt against the king**. The Despensers were hanged, Edward was **forced to abdicate** in favor of his teenage son, and **Roger and Isabella ruled as regents**. Eight months later, Edward II was horribly murdered. The regents ceded Gascony to France and acknowledged **Robert the Bruce** as king of an independent Scotland. In 1330, **Edward III** (r. 1327–77) had Mortimer hanged and began his own rule. Rising **tension with France** was exacerbated by Edward's embargo on wool exports to

Flanders, which triggered a **revolt** there against French domination. In 1337, Philip VI of France declared Edward's French territories forfeit, while Edward claimed the French crown, triggering the start of the **Hundred Years' War**.

Vijayanagar sculpture

Lord Hanuman, the Hindu monkey god, is shown carved on a rock surface in Vijayanagar, the heart of the last great Hindu empire.



“THE FIRST KING AFTER THE CONQUEST WHO WAS NOT A MAN OF BUSINESS.”

William Stubbs, English historian, describing Edward II, 1875

- 1321 Dante Alighieri dies in Ravenna (b.1265)
- 1323 Sultan Tughluq of Delhi annexes Telingana and repulses the Mongols
- 1324 Cannons used at the Siege of Metz
- 1324 Musa, emperor of Mali, annexes Timbuktu
- 1324 William of Ockham accused of heresy at Avignon for supporting the banned "Spiritual" Franciscans
- 1324–25 Musa's pilgrimage to Mecca
- 1325 The travels of Ibn Battuta begin
- 1325 Aztecs found Tenochtitlan

- 1326 Edward II captured by Roger Mortimer, then deposed and murdered the following year
- 1328 Accession of Philip VI, first Valois king of France
- 1328 Ludwig of Bavaria crowned Holy Roman Emperor
- 1330 Edward III of England begins reign
- 1331 Ottoman leader Ghazi Orkhan takes Nicaea
- 1332 Moscow becomes civil and ecclesiastical capital of Russia
- 1332 In Japan, Emperor Godaigo defeats the Hojo regency
- 1332 Negus of Abyssinia repulses an Islamic assault
- 1333 Black Death starts in China
- 1336 A Hindu rebellion establishes the Vijayanagar Empire in southern India
- 1336 Pisano's doors installed on the Florence baptistry
- 1337 Flemish rebellion triggered by English wool embargo
- 1337 Philip seizes Gascony from the English; start of the Hundred Years' War